

Using Fedora Electronic Lab

Do you feel that electronic design automation (EDA) tools running on Linux are too complicated to install and use? Read on to explore how easy and fun it is to install and use Fedora Electronic Lab on your computer



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With this month's EFY DVD, you can explore different free and Open Source tools that are specially designed for electronics engineers. The DVD is a bootable spin of Live Fedora 16 DVD, named Fedora Electronic Lab (FEL). You can run all the tools directly from the DVD drive even without installing these on your computer's hard disk. The EDA tools along with the operating system (OS) on the DVD are licensed under general-public licence (GPL) and don't require purchase of extra licences to activate their features.

Fedora Electronic Lab

Fedora Electronic Lab (FEL) is a compilation of tools that provides an advanced electronic design and simulation platform. It mainly targets the micro-nano electronics engineering field. Serious work on FEL was started in 2007 by Chitlesh Goorah, founder and architect of FEL, and Shakthi Kannan, developer. Apart from providing the best Open Source tools from the community at one place, it also creates a bridge between Open Source hardware and software communities. FEL strives to fulfil all the needs of each stage of the design flow.

What is Fedora and its spin?

Fedora is one of the most popular Linux-based OS. It is developed by the community-supported Fedora Project and sponsored by Red Hat. It allows you to do everything you can do with any other OS. Fedora spins are alternate versions of Fedora, specially compiled for various types of users by adding particular application sets and other customisations. Fedora Electronic Lab is one such spin of Fedora developed specifically for electronics engineers.

Using the DVD

The EFY DVD bundled with this anniversary issue can be used as a live Fedora Electronic Lab disk. To try the applications on the disk, you need to boot your computer using the DVD and let it



Fig. 1: Live DVD boot options



Fig. 2: FEL running in live mode

load with the default settings. To boot your computer using DVD ROM, set the DVD drive as the first boot device in your computer's BIOS settings. Most computers have this setting by default.

Now put the EFY DVD in the drive and restart your computer to boot from it. You will get a screen as seen in Fig. 1. Select 'Start Fedora 16' and press 'Enter' or just wait for it to start automatically. The booting process will take a few minutes depending on your system's hardware configuration. The recommended hardware configuration for using the DVD in live mode is a 1GHz processor with 1GB RAM and 10GB free hard disk space if you want to install the OS after trying it.

Once the live DVD successfully starts, you can click any application to try it. The OS can even be installed along with all the applications by just clicking the 'Install to Hard disk' icon as shown in Fig. 3.